

Exp 2: Setting up a Zoho Creator account and exploring the platform architecture and interface

1. Introduction

- **What is Zoho Creator:** A cloud-based, low-code application development platform by Zoho Corporation that lets users build custom business applications with minimal hand-written code.
- **Use cases:** Education management, inventory tracking, CRM, workflow automation, and other business-process applications.
- **This exercise:** A newly created organization account was set up and every major module of the Creator console was explored and documented.
- **Modules explored:** Applications, Microservices, Environments, Mobile, Portal, Users, Organization, Governance, Metrics, Operations, and Billing.
- **Purpose of documenting:** Together, these modules illustrate how a modern SaaS low-code platform is structured — from development to deployment to administration.

2. Objective of the Study

- To create and configure a new account on the Zoho Creator platform.
- To explore the primary navigation structure of the Creator console — the Develop, Deploy, and Manage sections.
- To understand the purpose and functionality of each module available to a Super Admin user.
- To document the platform's architecture through a layered architecture diagram.
- To relate observed interface elements to core management concepts such as role-based access control, multi-stage deployment, and governance.

3. Overview of Zoho Creator

- **Platform type:** A cloud-based, low-code application development platform, part of the larger Zoho suite of business productivity tools.
- **Who it's for:** Both citizen developers (non-programmers) and professional programmers.
- **Building tools:** Drag-and-drop form builders and visual workflow designers.
- **Scripting language:** Deluge (Data Enriched Language for the Universal Grid Environment) — used to write custom business logic.
- **Console structure:** Organized into three functional groups visible in the left navigation panel: DEVELOP (Applications, Microservices), DEPLOY (Environments, Mobile, Portal), and MANAGE (Users, Organization, Governance, Metrics, Operations, Billing).

- **Why this grouping matters:** It mirrors the typical lifecycle of a business application — design and development, staged deployment, and ongoing administration.

4. Account Setup and Platform Walkthrough

4.1 Application Dashboard

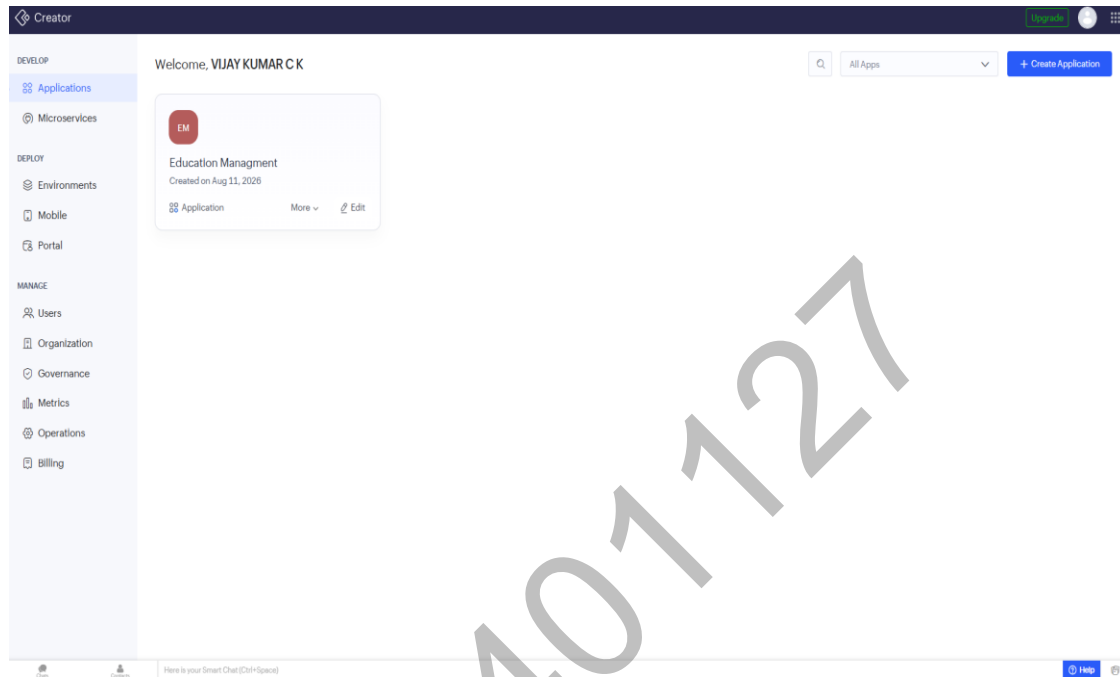


Figure 4.1: Applications dashboard showing the newly created 'Education Management' application.

- **Login confirmation:** Personalized welcome message 'Welcome, VIJAY KUMAR C K' confirms the account was created successfully.
- **Application listed:** 'Education Management' app, created on 11 August 2026, shown with an auto-generated 'EM' icon.
- **Available actions:** Application (open), More (additional options), and Edit — to open, configure, or modify the app.
- **Top-right controls:** Search bar, 'All Apps' filter, and the 'Create Application' button — the entry point for building a new app from scratch or a template.

4.2 Microservices Module

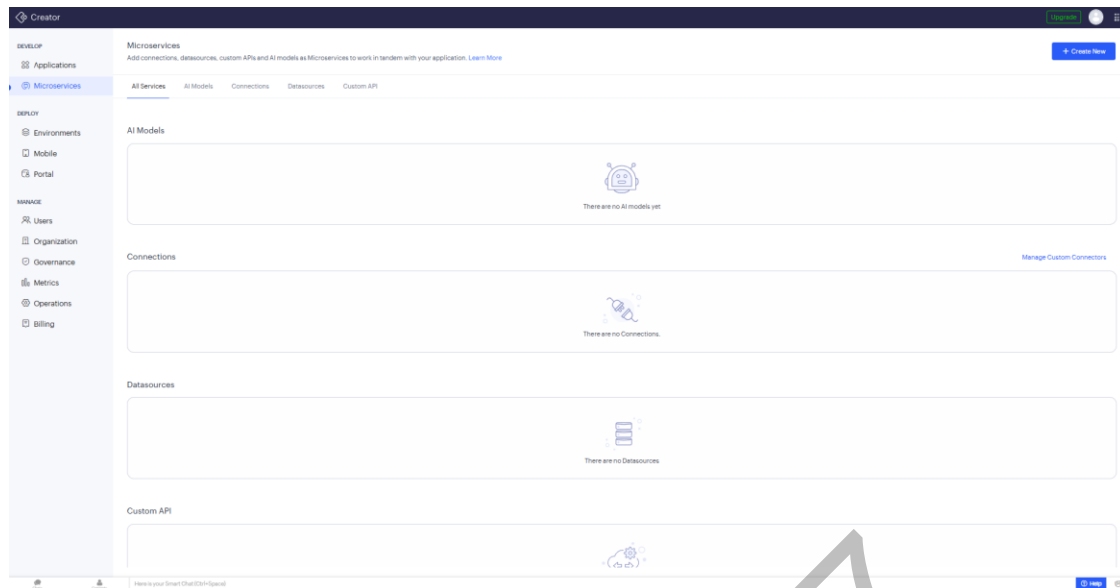


Figure 4.2: Microservices module listing AI Models, Connections, Datasources, and Custom API categories.

- **Purpose:** Lets an application be extended using modular, reusable services — currently empty for this new account.
- **AI Models:** Would allow integrating machine-learning capabilities into an application.
- **Connections:** Link the app to third-party services, e.g., payment gateways or Google services.
- **Datasources:** Allow the application to read from or write to external databases.
- **Custom API:** Allows exposing or consuming REST-based application programming interfaces.
- **Key takeaway:** Demonstrates a service-oriented architecture where core app logic is decoupled from auxiliary services.

4.3 Environments (Deployment Space)

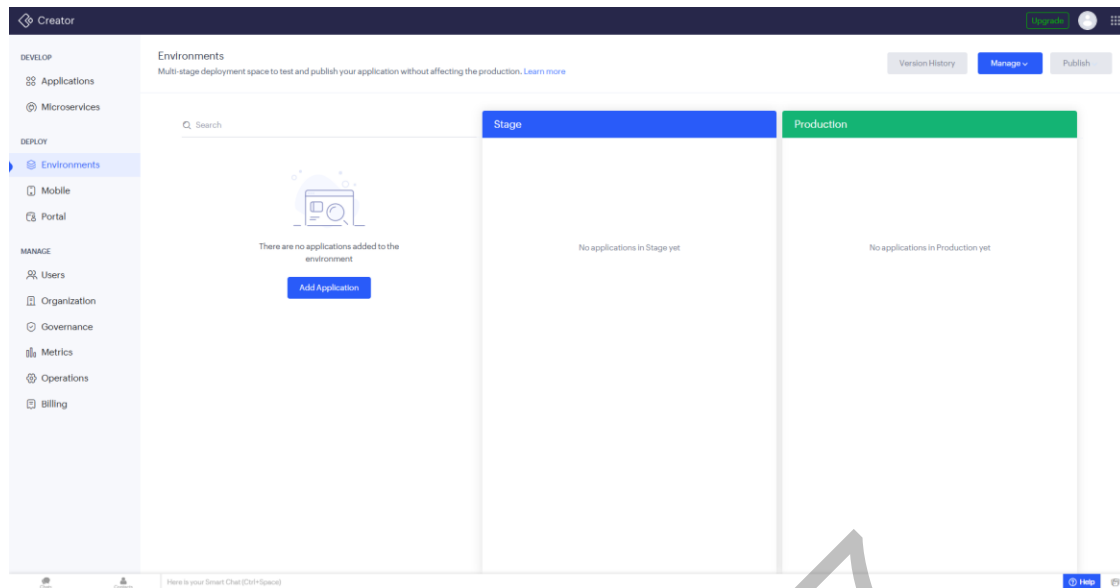


Figure 4.3: Environments screen showing the Stage and Production deployment spaces.

- **Stage environment:** Shown in blue; used for safely testing an application before release.
- **Production environment:** Shown in green; the live environment used by end users.
- **Current status:** Both show 'No applications' yet, along with an 'Add Application' button.
- **Why it matters:** Mirrors standard software-engineering practice — testing before publishing reduces the risk of business disruption.
- **Toolbar controls:** Version History, Manage, and Publish — used to govern the release process.

4.4 Mobile Application Distribution

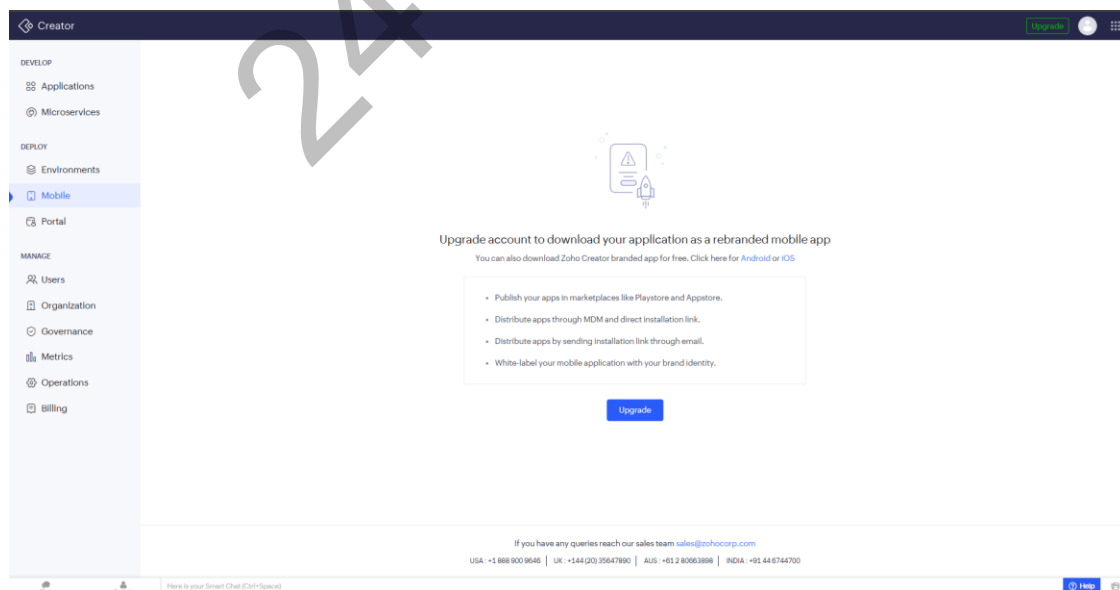


Figure 4.4: Mobile module prompting an account upgrade to enable rebranded mobile app distribution.

- **Purpose:** Package Creator applications as native, white-labelled mobile apps for the Play Store and App Store.
- **Plan restriction:** Feature is locked behind a paid plan on this free account.
- **Upgrade benefits shown:** Publishing to app marketplaces, distribution via MDM or direct installation links, and full white-labelling with the organization's brand.
- **Free alternative:** A Zoho-branded app for Android and iOS is offered for users who do not wish to upgrade.

4.5 Portal Configuration

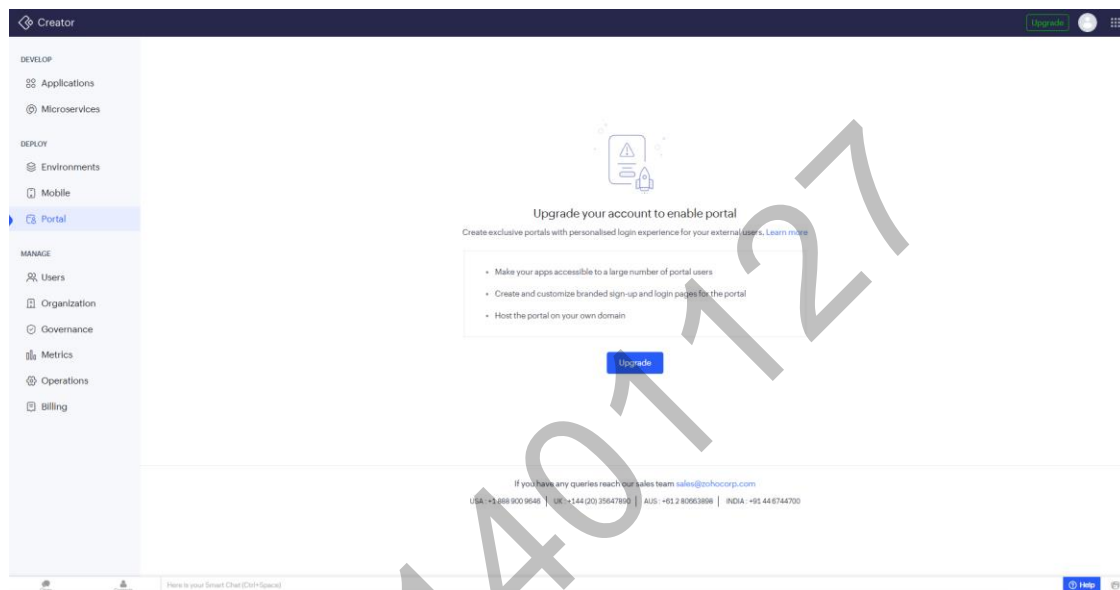


Figure 4.5: Portal module requiring an account upgrade to enable an external-user portal.

- **What a Portal is:** A dedicated, branded access point for external users (e.g., students or parents) to interact with select parts of the app.
- **Plan restriction:** Also gated behind a paid plan, similar to the Mobile module.
- **Benefits shown:** Access for large numbers of external users, customizable branded sign-up/login pages, and hosting on the organization's own domain.

4.6 User Management

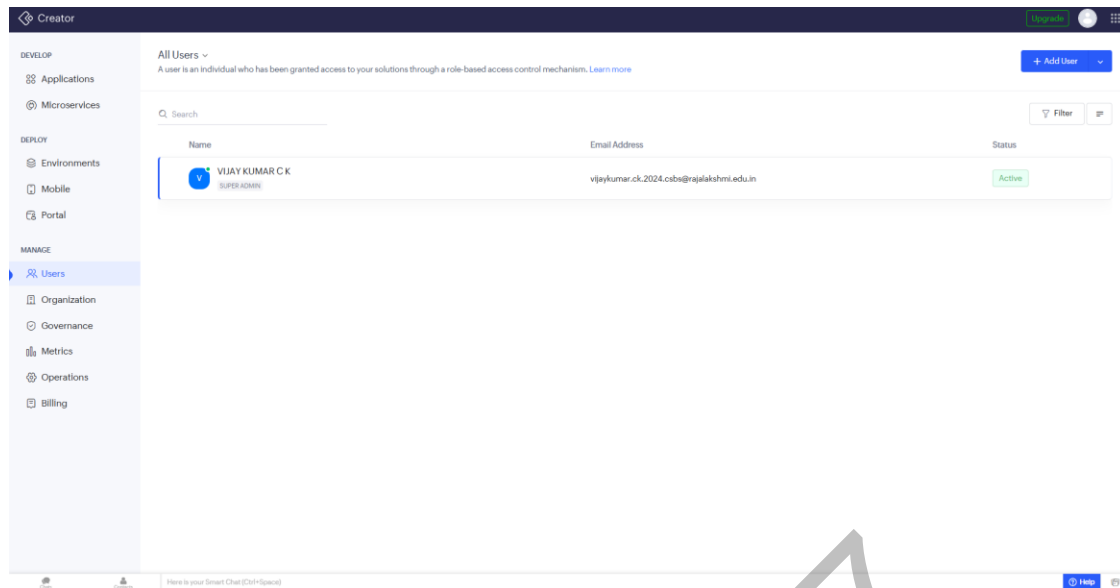


Figure 4.6: All Users screen listing the account owner with the Super Admin role.

- **Users listed:** One user — VIJAY KUMAR C K — with role SUPER ADMIN and status 'Active'.
- **Registered email:** vijaykumar.ck.2024.csbs@rajalakshmi.edu.in
- **Available tools:** 'Add User' button to invite others, plus search and filter options.
- **Concept demonstrated:** Role-based access control (RBAC) — permissions are assigned to named roles, not directly to individuals.

4.7 Organization Settings

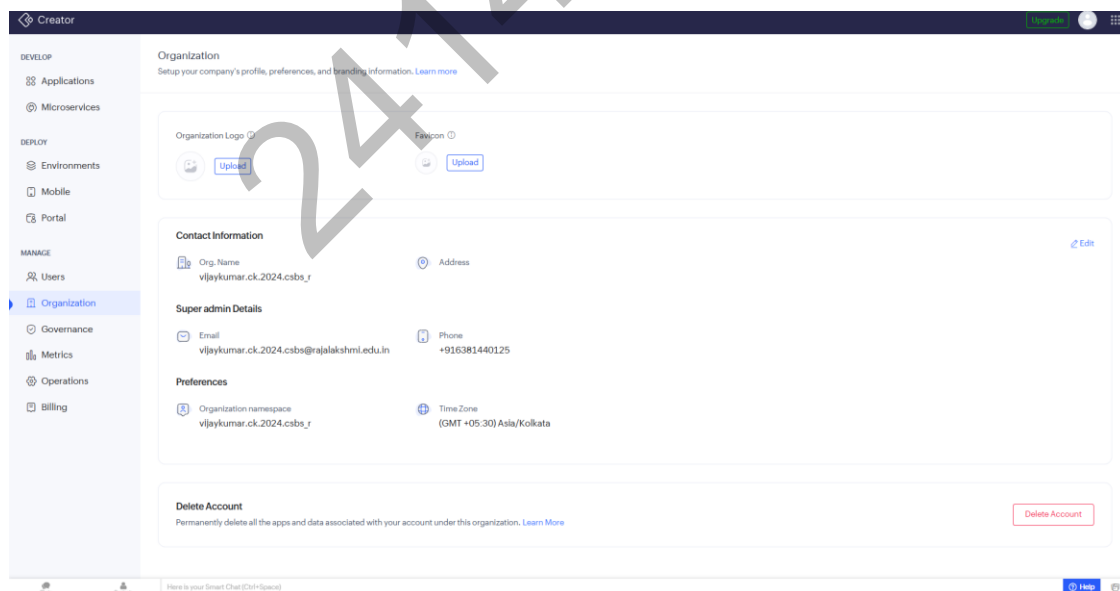


Figure 4.7: Organization settings displaying company profile, super-admin details, and preferences.

- **Branding:** Options to upload an Organization Logo and Favicon.

- **Contact information:** Organization name (vijaykumar.ck.2024.csbs_r) and address fields.
- **Super admin details:** Registered email and phone number.
- **Preferences:** Organization namespace and time zone — set to (GMT +05:30) Asia/Kolkata.
- **Delete Account option:** Permanently removes all applications and data — gives the user full, reversible control over their own data.

4.8 Governance and Security Policies

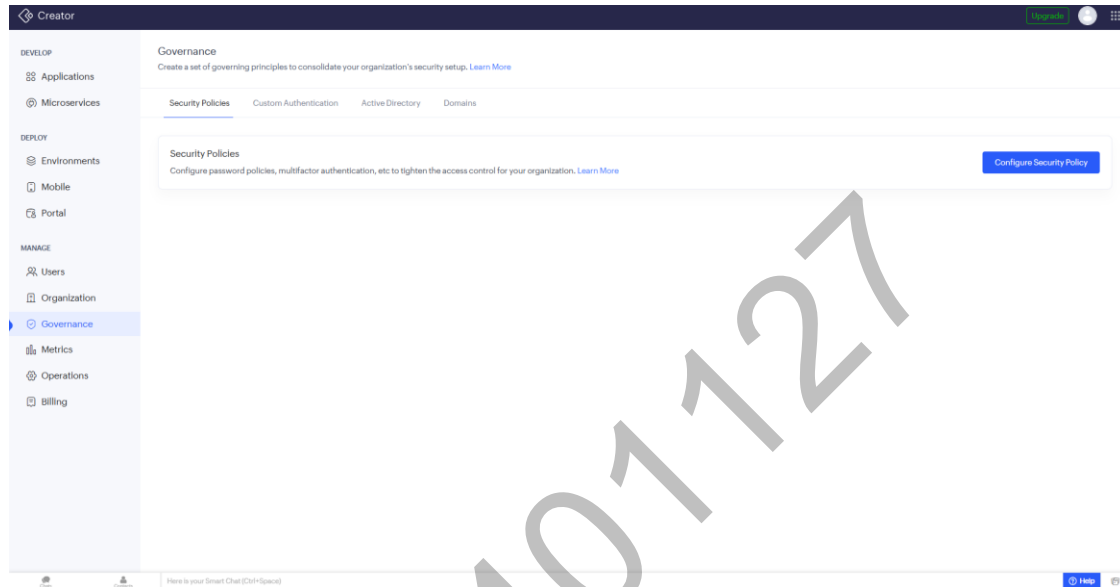


Figure 4.8: Governance module with Security Policies, Custom Authentication, Active Directory, and Domains tabs.

- **Security Policies (active tab):** Configure password policies and multi-factor authentication (MFA) via 'Configure Security Policy'.
- **Custom Authentication:** Would allow integrating third-party identity providers.
- **Active Directory:** Enables enterprise directory-service synchronization.
- **Domains:** Restricts access to specific verified email domains.
- **Overall purpose:** Consolidates the organization's security posture in one place — standard enterprise governance controls.

4.9 Metrics and Analytics

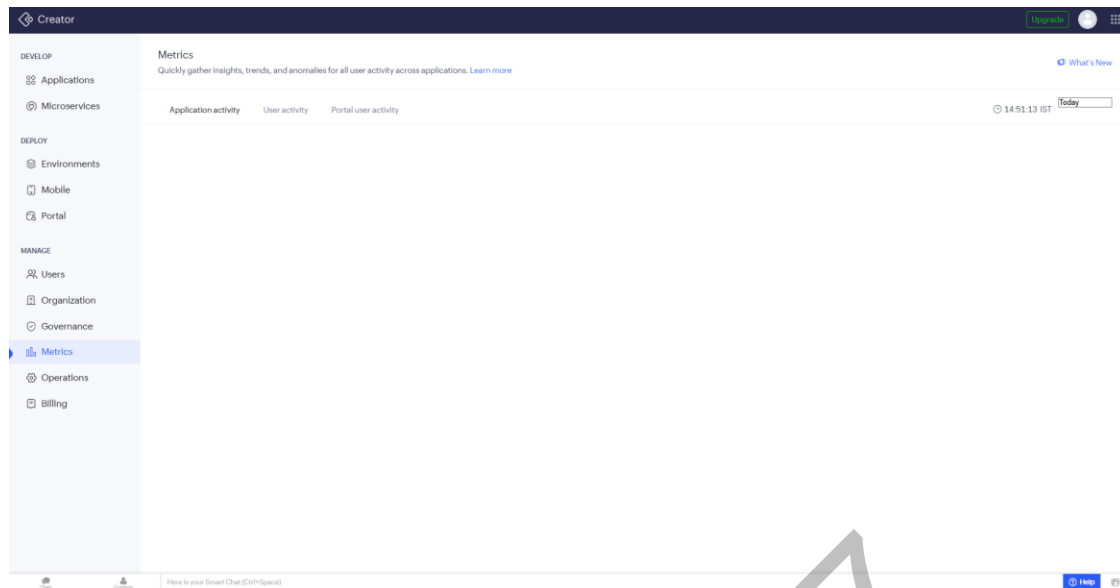


Figure 4.9: Metrics dashboard for tracking application and user activity.

- **Views available:** Application Activity, User Activity, and Portal User Activity.
- **Live indicators:** A live clock (shown as 14:51:13 IST) and a date-range filter (currently 'Today').
- **Current state:** Empty, since no application traffic has been generated yet.
- **Intended use:** In an active deployment, would surface usage trends and anomalies to support data-driven decisions.

4.10 Operations Console

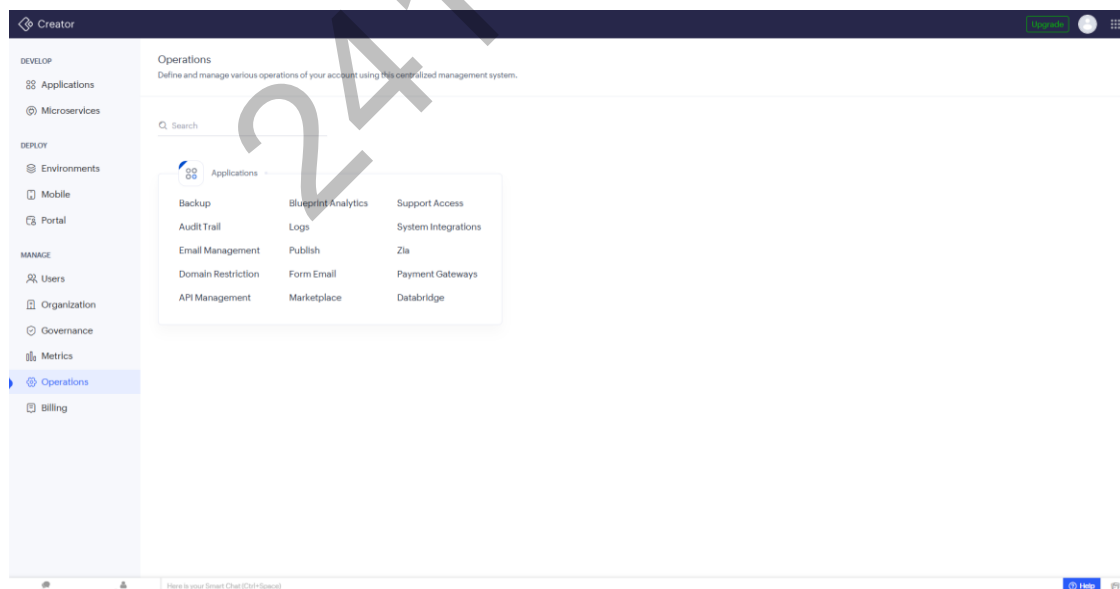


Figure 4.10: Operations console listing centralized administrative tools under the Applications category.

- **Data protection tools:** Backup and Audit Trail.
- **Extensibility tools:** API Management, Marketplace, and System Integrations.
- **Communication tools:** Email Management and Form Email.
- **Monitoring tools:** Logs, Blueprint Analytics.
- **Other tools:** Publish, Domain Restriction, Support Access, Zia (Zoho's AI assistant), Payment Gateways, and Databridge.
- **Overall purpose:** A centralized control panel for account-wide administrative tasks, reflecting the breadth of control given to a Super Admin.

4.11 Billing and Subscription

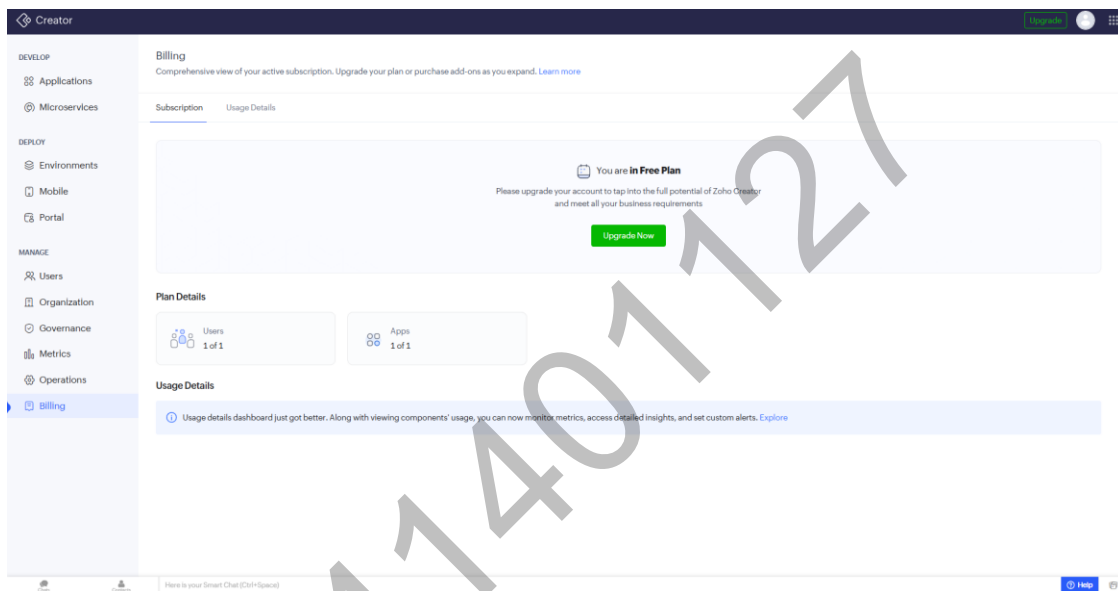


Figure 4.11: Billing page showing the account's Free Plan status and usage limits.

- **Current plan:** Free Plan, with an 'Upgrade Now' prompt to access full platform capabilities.
- **Plan limits:** 1 of 1 Users and 1 of 1 Apps — explains why Mobile and Portal required an upgrade.
- **Usage Details tab:** Lets the admin monitor component-level usage, insights, and set custom alerts.

5. Platform Architecture

Based on the navigation structure explored above, the Zoho Creator platform can be represented as a five-layer architecture, moving from the end-user access points down to the underlying cloud infrastructure. The diagram below (Figure 5.1) summarizes this layered architecture as inferred from the console's own organization of features.

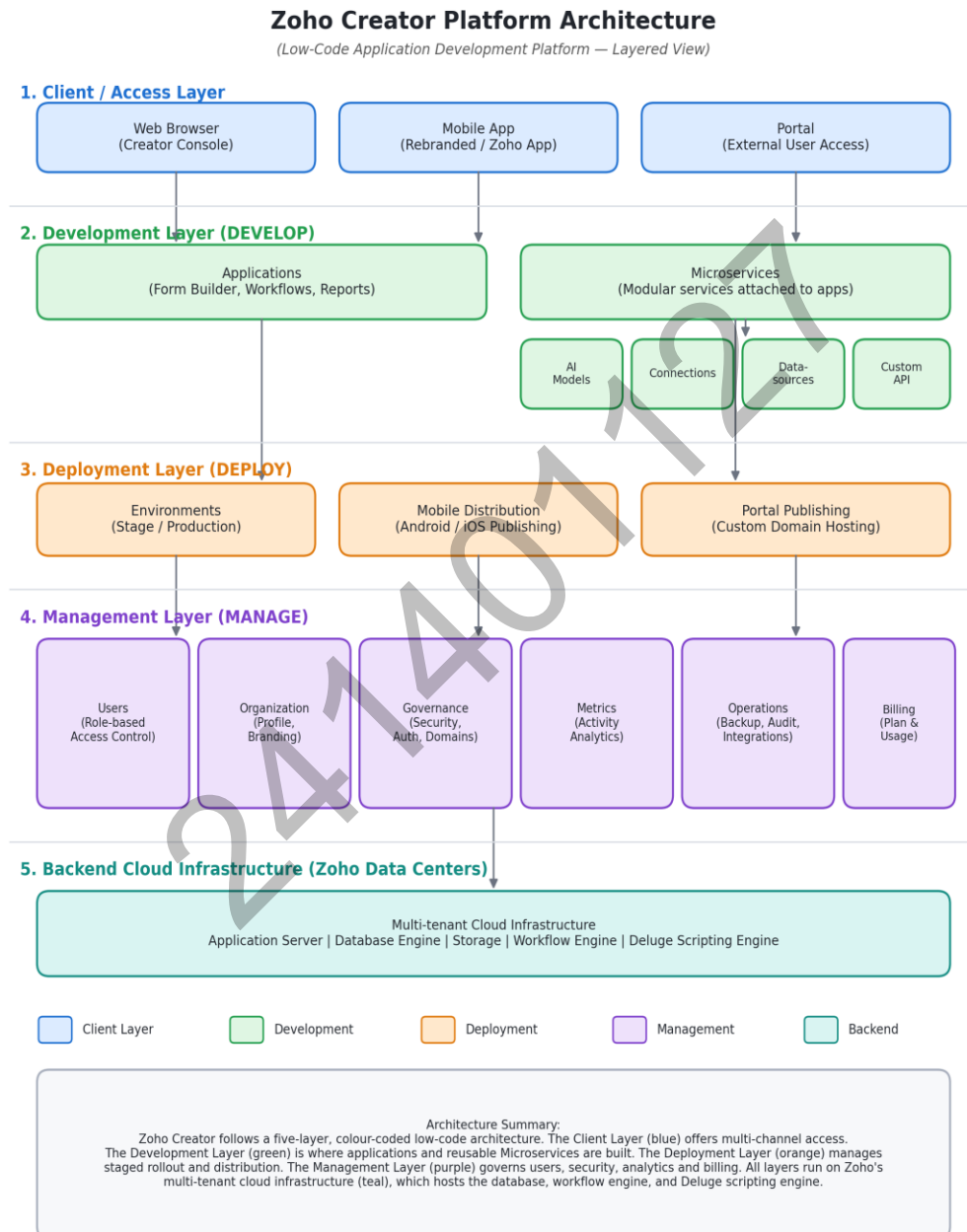


Figure 5.1: Layered architecture of the Zoho Creator platform.

5.1 Explanation of Architectural Layers

- **Layer 1 — Client / Access Layer:** The outermost layer through which users reach the platform — the web-based Creator Console (developers/admins), a rebranded or Zoho-branded Mobile App (end users), and a Portal (external stakeholders such as students or customers with limited, branded access).
- **Layer 2 — Development Layer (DEVELOP):** Contains the app-building tools. 'Applications' is the core low-code builder for forms, pages, workflows, and reports. 'Microservices' supplements apps with AI Models, Connections, Datasources, and Custom APIs, following the principle of loose coupling.
- **Layer 3 — Deployment Layer (DEPLOY):** Manages controlled release. 'Environments' enforces a Stage-then-Production workflow (standard DevOps practice); 'Mobile Distribution' and 'Portal Publishing' extend the same app to mobile channels and custom-domain portals.
- **Layer 4 — Management Layer (MANAGE):** Provides administrative oversight: Users (RBAC), Organization (branding/preferences), Governance (security/authentication/domains), Metrics (analytics), Operations (backup/audit/integrations), and Billing (plan/usage tracking).
- **Layer 5 — Backend Cloud Infrastructure:** Zoho's multi-tenant cloud infrastructure — application servers, database engine, storage, workflow engine, and the Deluge scripting engine — powers every layer above it, even though it is not directly visible in the console.

6. Observations and Learning Outcomes

- The Zoho Creator free plan is deliberately limited to one user and one application — sufficient for learning/prototyping, not production use — a common freemium SaaS strategy.
- The platform's navigation mirrors the natural lifecycle of an application: Develop, Deploy, and Manage — standard software-engineering and IT-service-management practice.
- Governance, Metrics, and Operations show that a modern low-code platform is not just a development tool but also an enterprise administration suite.
- Advanced features (Mobile rebranding, Portal, custom domains) are monetized as premium upgrades — a tiered pricing model typical of cloud software vendors.
- Separating Stage and Production environments reinforces the management principle of controlled change, minimizing the risk of business disruption from untested releases.

7. Conclusion

- **What was learned:** Practical insight into how a modern low-code, cloud-based application development platform is structured and administered.
- **Modules covered:** Applications, Microservices, Environments, Mobile, Portal, Users, Organization, Governance, Metrics, Operations, and Billing.
- **Key finding:** Zoho Creator organizes its functionality into clear development, deployment, and management stages, all supported by a common multi-tenant cloud backend.
- **Broader value:** Such platforms lower the barrier to building business applications while still incorporating enterprise-grade concerns — role-based access control, staged deployment, governance, and usage-based billing.
- **Relevance to Management studies:** Offers transferable understanding of SaaS platform design and core management concepts such as access control, resource governance, and lifecycle management.

References

- Zoho Corporation, "Zoho Creator Documentation," available at the official Zoho Creator help portal.
- Screenshots captured directly from the author's own Zoho Creator account (Organization: vijaykumar.ck.2024.csbs_r) on 11 August 2026.